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American Goldfinch

*Spinus tristis***QUICK STATS**

Length	4.3 – 5.1 in (11 – 13 cm)
Wingspan	7.5 – 8.7 in (19 – 22 cm)
Weight	0.4 – 0.7 oz (11 – 20 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 3–6 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The American Goldfinch is one of the most brilliantly colored birds in North America — the male's summer plumage of blazing canary yellow and jet black is unmistakable at any feeder. Known affectionately as the "wild canary," it is one of the few finches that undergoes a complete molt twice a year, transitioning from dazzling yellow in summer to subdued olive-brown in winter. It is also one of the latest nesters in North America, deliberately timing its breeding to coincide with the peak availability of thistle seeds in late summer — the primary food used to feed its nestlings.

HABITAT & RANGE

The American Goldfinch breeds across southern Canada and the northern two-thirds of the United States, from British Columbia east to Newfoundland and south through the Appalachians. In winter, northern populations migrate south, and the species can then be found across the entire continental US and into northern Mexico. It inhabits open and semi-open environments: weedy fields, meadows, floodplains, roadsides, forest edges, orchards, and suburban gardens. It shows a strong preference for areas with abundant thistles, sunflowers, and other composite flowers.

DIET & FEEDING

- Nyjer (thistle) seed — the top choice, attracts large flocks
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and hulled chips
- Native thistle, coneflower, and sunflower seeds in the wild
- Dandelion, aster, and goldenrod seeds
- Almost entirely vegetarian — rarely eats insects
- Birch and alder catkins in late winter

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

American Goldfinches are highly social birds that travel in flocks year-round, even during the breeding season when most songbirds become territorial. Flocks can number in the hundreds at productive feeding sites. Their flight pattern is distinctively undulating — a series of flaps followed by a glide — and they frequently call in flight with a cheerful "per-chick-o-ree" that announces their presence overhead. Males are loosely territorial around nest sites but tolerate other goldfinches feeding nearby. They are among the most acrobatic feeder birds, clinging upside-down to thistle socks and swinging seed heads with ease.

NESTING & BREEDING

The American Goldfinch is the latest nesting songbird in North America, typically not beginning until late June or July — months after most other species have already fledged young. This timing is not accidental: it synchronizes perfectly with the peak ripening of thistle and other composite seeds. The female weaves an exceptionally tight, compact cup nest of plant fibers and thistle down, bound with spider silk, in the fork of a shrub or small tree. The nest is so tightly woven it can hold water. She lays 4–6 pale blue eggs, incubating them alone for 12–14 days while the male feeds her. Both parents feed nestlings regurgitated seeds. Young fledge at 11–17 days.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The goldfinch's song is a long, rambling series of musical twitters, warbles, and trills — bright and cheerful, delivered from a perch or in flight. The flight call "per-chick-o-ree" or "po-ta-to-chip" is one of the most recognizable sounds of open country in summer. A soft "swee" contact call keeps flock members in touch. Males sing most actively from late spring through summer.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
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With a population estimated at 42 million individuals, the American Goldfinch remains common but has shown gradual declines in recent decades, linked to loss of weedy meadow habitat, agricultural intensification, and the reduction of native thistles. Planting native wildflowers — especially coneflowers, black-eyed Susans, and native thistles — is one of the most effective ways to support goldfinch populations.

FEEDER TIPS

- Nyjer (thistle) seed in a dedicated thistle sock or tube feeder
- Expect large flocks — install multiple feeders to reduce competition
- Keep nyjer fresh — it goes stale quickly and goldfinches will reject it
- Plant native coneflowers and leave seed heads standing through winter
- Goldfinches arrive later in the day — most active mid-morning to afternoon

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Body (male, summer)	Brilliant canary yellow
Wings & tail	Black with white wing bars
Forehead patch (male)	Black cap — front only
Body (female)	Olive-yellow, duller than male
Body (male, winter)	Olive-brown — loses bright yellow
Bill	Short, conical, orange-pink

COLOR ME!

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